SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #57 · FAITH & BELIEF

“If I don’t feel close to God, He has left me.”

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Where it often comes from

Times of spiritual dryness after seasons of closeness. Depression or grief that dulls all feelings, including spiritual ones. Teaching that stressed feelings as proof of God’s presence. Sin or guilt that made you feel distant. Comparing your quiet faith with others’ emotional experiences.

What Scripture teaches

God’s presence does not depend on your feelings. His Word promises, “He will never leave you nor forsake you.” There is nowhere you can go to escape His Spirit. Even the psalmists sometimes felt as though God had forgotten them and hidden His face, but they kept talking to Him. Feelings of distance are real and painful, but they are not a reliable report of where God is.

> *“The LORD Himself goes before you; He will be with you. He will never leave you nor forsake you. Do not be afraid or discouraged”* **(Deuteronomy 31:8)**.

Also see

> “Where can I go to escape Your Spirit? Where can I flee from Your presence? If I ascend to the heavens, You are there; if I make my bed in Sheol, You are there. If I rise on the wings of the dawn, if I settle by the farthest sea, even there Your hand will guide me; Your right hand will hold me fast” **(Psalm 139:7–10)**.

> “Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness” **(Isaiah 41:10)**.

> “How long, O LORD? Will You forget me forever? How long will You hide Your face from me? How long must I wrestle in my soul, with sorrow in my heart each day? How long will my enemy dominate me?” **(Psalm 13:1–2)**.

> “Yet I am always with You; You hold my right hand. You guide me with Your counsel, and later receive me in glory. Whom have I in heaven but You? And on earth I desire no one besides You. My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever” **(Psalm 73:23–26)**.

Common self-statements

- God has abandoned me.
- I can’t feel Him, so He must be gone.
- I must have done something to drive Him away.
- Other people feel God, but I don’t.
- My prayers just hit the ceiling.
- God is close to others, not to me.

Common logical errors

- **Emotional reasoning:** Treating a feeling of distance as proof that God has left.
- **Personalization:** Assuming the dryness must be your fault.
- **Comparison:** Measuring God’s presence by other people’s feelings.

- **Fortune telling:** Predicting that you will always feel this way.

Challenging questions

- What does God promise in Deuteronomy 31:8?
- Where can I go that God is not, according to Psalm 139?
- Did the psalmists ever feel forgotten? What did they do?
- Could depression, grief, or exhaustion be affecting my feelings?
- Is God's presence based on His promise or my feelings?
- Have I had dry times before that passed?
- What would faithfulness look like during a dry season?

Truth summary

> Even when I don't feel close to God, He has not left me. He promises never to leave me or forsake me. There is nowhere I can go to escape His presence. My feelings may be dry or numb, but God is still holding my hand. I can keep talking to Him and trust His promise.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- God, Present Everywhere
- Loneliness
- Faith
- Trust
- Depression, Symptoms of

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Depression
- Love
- Prayer

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> **Overcoming Depression** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I don't feel close to God, He has left me"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I don't feel close to God, He has left me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What does God promise in Deuteronomy 31:8?
- ☐ Where can I go that God is not?
- ☐ What did the psalmists do when they felt forgotten?
- ☐ Could depression or grief affect my feelings?
- ☐ Is God's presence based on promise or feeling?
- ☐ Have dry times passed before?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God will never leave me nor forsake me.
- ☐ I cannot go anywhere God is not.
- ☐ My feelings are not a report of where God is.
- ☐ God holds my right hand, even when I feel nothing.
- ☐ I can keep talking to God in dry seasons.
- ☐ God is the strength of my heart.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Deuteronomy 31:8**
  "The LORD Himself goes before you; He will be with you. He will never leave you nor forsake you. Do not be afraid or discouraged."
- [ ] **Psalm 139:7–10**
  "Where can I go to escape Your Spirit? Where can I flee from Your presence? If I ascend to the heavens, You are there; if I make my bed in Sheol, You are there. If I rise on the wings of the dawn, if I settle by the farthest sea, even there Your hand will guide me; Your right hand will hold me fast."
- [ ] **Isaiah 41:10**
  "Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness."
- [ ] **Psalm 13:1–2**
  "How long, O LORD? Will You forget me forever? How long will You hide Your face from me? How long must I wrestle in my soul, with sorrow in my heart each day? How long will my enemy dominate me?"
- [ ] **Psalm 73:23–26**
  "Yet I am always with You; You hold my right hand. You guide me with Your counsel, and later receive me in glory. Whom have I in heaven but You? And on earth I desire no one besides You. My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Presence log:** Each day, write: "God is with me today," and one small sign of His care, even if I didn't feel it.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Deuteronomy 31:8 becomes: "The LORD Himself goes before **Sarah**; He will be with **her**. He will never leave **her** nor forsake **her**. **She** need not be afraid or discouraged."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "God, Present Everywhere" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Read Psalm 13 aloud,** noticing how the writer moves from "How long?" to trust.
- ☐ **Pray for five minutes each day** even if you feel nothing, and mark it on your tracker.
- ☐ **Check the basics:** sleep, health, grief, and stress, which can all dull spiritual feelings.
- ☐ **Ask a mature believer** about a dry season they went through and what helped.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I don't feel close to God, He has left me": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	I prayed even without feeling
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I don't feel close to God, He has left me.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I don't feel close to You right now. Help me reject the lie that You have left me. Thank You that You will never leave me nor forsake me, and that I cannot go anywhere You are not. Hold my hand through this dry season and help me trust Your promise. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.